

Design, Deployment, and Evaluation of an Open-Source College Football Championship Prediction Model

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Abstract. This paper introduces a new open-source ranking model for college football. Historically, teams have been ranked by voters and this has led to numerous controversies and allegations of human bias. Additionally, many polls were designed last century and do not consider the new nuances of the College Football Playoff (CFP) era. Our model is trained only on playoff seasons and is purely driven by quantitative metrics. We explain our research framework and model architecture then share the results. Before the playoffs began our model successfully predicted the champion Indiana Hoosiers and had the runner-up Miami Hurricanes rated higher than the CFP Selection Committee.

Keywords: Football, Gridiron Football, Sports Polls, Predictive Analytics, American Football, College Football, Sports Analytics, Player-Ranking, Data Science, Multivariate Regression.

1 Introduction

In the United States of America ranking men's college football (CFB) teams has been a contentious debate for over a century. It was easier in the early 1890s when "The Game" [1] [2] between Harvard and Yale was most important. However, soon afterward when there were over a hundred teams [3], it became more of a challenge as they cannot play each other each year since the regular season is only 12 games long.

Given these mathematical constraints, how could a national champion be reliably chosen? Historically, polls have been one approach [4]. They are public rankings designed to pick the top 25 teams before, during, and after the season. The best team was determined by voters each time. For most of CFB history, there was no championship or playoff. The top teams did not face one another in a tournament to determine the number one squad. The champion was a matter of opinion and ultimately decided by the polls.

Of course, human voters are fallible. Traditional polls are subjective, biased, and inconsistent. In years like 1915 instead of one national poll champion, there were four [5]. This often led to famous programs from popular conferences being at the top due to big-name brand recognition. The Bowl Championship Series (BCS) [6] [7] was an

attempt to remove human bias from the rankings, instead relying on a proprietary mathematical formula. It was used from 1998 to 2013, but those results still led to controversies [24]. Many fans were not fully comfortable with the idea of “a computer” deciding which two teams would be facing off in the national championship game instead of a playoff.

A famous example of an odd team out was the 2004 Auburn Tigers, who did not get a chance to compete for the national championship despite going undefeated and winning the traditionally powerful Southeastern Conference (SEC). The University of Southern California (USC) and the University of Oklahoma (OU) also went undefeated, but they started higher in the preseason polls relative to Auburn’s initial ranking of #17. This kept them just out of reach for the Tigers.

The fact that Auburn never lost a game yet did not compete in the final game of the year seemed unfair to many. Due to the BCS model, situations like this could occur where there were only two musical chairs and three teams seeking a seat. The proposed solution was the current College Football Playoff (CFP) format.

Instead of the voters or computers immediately narrowing things down to one winner or two teams playing in a national championship game, the committee is tasked with selecting 12 teams who compete for the crown in a playoff. The original playoff consisted of four teams (2014-2023), with the expansion to 12 happening in 2024. Given how the CFB landscape has changed so drastically, we felt that a new type of ranking was necessary.

Put simply, our motivation was captured by co-author Isaih in 2024 [8] “SEC Bias and the overall discourse over CFB playoff rankings this year and last have driven me so nuts that I’m very tempted to come up with a new computer ranking system to replace the BCS by next year.” That next year we made a quantitative ranking with the objective of predicting the likelihood that a given team will win the championship.

Our training data was constrained only to the CFP-era to preserve temporal validity. We do not use any poll rankings; it is purely based on interpretable numbers, hopefully free from recency and big-name brand bias of humans. The CFP era (2014–present) represents a structurally distinct decision environment. We do not care who is hypothetically the #1 team in abstract. We want to know who will emerge victorious from the playoff bracket.

Another issue is that many historical rankings lack transparency, reproducibility, and consistency. It is not clear who voted for which team nor is the methodology transparent. While the AP poll does publish its methodology and voters [9] the Coach’s poll ballots are kept secret [10]. Other polls out there, like the BCS, are “proprietary” or “closed source” to borrow a term from software development. Fans cannot see the math nor adapt it to their own specifications. On the contrary, the code for our model is open. It contributes to the open-source sports analytics community. We want to give fans a poll they can easily understand and modify to suit their needs. There is a near-infinite amount of discussion and passion for the topic out there as many people across the country have a vested interest in CFB as fans want their team to have a fair shot at being crowned national champions. The game and the way teams are measured is ever evolving so we view our model as a step in the right direction to meet fans where they are at today and to give them a path towards more accurate analyses in the future.

This is an important facet of the novelty of our model. In addition, it is complemented by champion profile criteria derived from actual CFP winners. The games are over so we evaluate results of how our CFP-era–constrained training model fared during the 2025–26 season.

2 Research Design

To be clear, we are not researching football as is used in most countries or “soccer”. Our focus is North American or “gridiron” football. If you are not familiar with the game, see our 2025 paper [11] for a brief explanation of rules and positions from a sports analytics perspective designed for an international audience. That paper describes the National Football League (NFL) while this one is focused on teams in the National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA) Division I Football Bowl Subdivision (FBS), also referred to as “college football” in general parlance.

A gap analysis of modern polls revealed a need for an objective, reproducible ranking system. Existing rankings are not optimized to work for CFP prediction, specifically. Most systems either rely on subjective inputs or ignore institutional regime shifts like the CFP. We sought to predict one thing: *Who will win the CFP and become national champion?*

This is a different goal than abstractly answering “Who is the best college football team?” as most traditional polls seemingly seek to find. Of course, we still considered using AP poll rankings as a predictor. Including them made the predictive model machine learning results “better” in terms of predictive accuracy, as shown in subsection 3.3, but we wanted ours to be “pure”. Thus, we only chose metrics that were quantitative and free from human selector bias.

The research question guiding this study became: *What levels of Win Percentage (Win%), Simple Rating System (SRS), and Strength of Schedule (SOS) are associated with winning a championship in the CFP-era?*

We defined winning a championship as (y). A binary dependent variable where $y = 1$ indicates CFP champion, where $y = 0$ indicates non-champion. We had three independent variables:

- $\beta_1 = \text{Win\%}$ is the proportion of games won in season.
- $\beta_2 = \text{SOS}$, or Strength of Schedule, is a rating that “is denominated in points above/below average, where zero is average.” [12] A high positive SOS means they faced a difficult schedule, where a negative SOS indicates a weak schedule.
- $\beta_3 = \text{SRS}$, or Simple Rating System, is “a rating that takes into account average point differential and SOS ... it should be noted that margin of victory has been assigned a lower bound of 7 points and an upper bound of 24 points.” [12] A higher SRS indicates a stronger team.

SRS and SOS are treated as distinct metrics. Our global model null hypothesis is that all coefficients in the model (Win Percentage, SRS, and SOS) are equal to zero. In other

words, none of the three predictor variables have a statistically significant relationship with the response variable, y .

$H_0: \beta_1 = \beta_2 = \beta_3 = 0$ (all coefficients equal zero; predictors have no effect)

The global alternative hypothesis states that not every coefficient is simultaneously equal to zero.

H_a : Not all $\beta_i = 0$ (at least 1 predictor significantly affects championship probability).

The first single variable null hypothesis is that Win% is not a statistically significant predictor of championship probability when controlling for SRS and SOS.

$H_{01}: \beta_1 = 0$

The first single variable alternative hypothesis is that Win% is a statistically significant predictor of championship probability when controlling for SRS and SOS.

$H_{a1}: \beta_1 \neq 0$

The second single variable null hypothesis tests whether SOS is associated with championship probability when controlling for Win% and SRS within the fitted model.

$H_{02}: \beta_2 = 0$

$H_{a2}: \beta_2 \neq 0$

The final single variable null hypothesis tests whether SRS is a significant predictor, holding Win% and SOS constant.

$H_{03}: \beta_3 = 0$

$H_{a3}: \beta_3 \neq 0$

To achieve our goal of making an open-source poll that successfully predicts the champion, we chose a hybrid approach. While we wanted a sound statistical foundation for our model, we prioritized machine learning (ML) results for predictability.

3 Deployment Methodology

Our software stack utilized Jupyter notebooks, Python code, and artificial intelligence (AI) large language models (LLMs). Specifically, we leveraged ChatGPT 5.1 from OpenAI, DeepSeek AI Version 3.2, Perplexity, Claude Sonnet 4.5, and Claude haiku 4.5 to assist with code generation, debugging, and methodological discussions.

For statistical testing of logistic regression we used the statsmodels python library. In the following subsections we detail our methodological approach from acquiring data, to architecting the model, determining championship criteria and then evaluating metrics.

3.1 Data Acquisition

We considered multiple sources, but decided upon the famous, wonderful Sports Reference, LLC college football [13] site as our primary source. It has over a century and a half of data from 1869 to 2025.

We created a custom web scraper in Python to acquire the data. It downloads from the URL www.sports-reference.com/cfb/schools/ each school's all-years cumulative overall win-loss record for regular season play and bowl games as well as its SOS and SRS data to derive a master list of schools.

This list is then traversed and the granular team-year data required for our analysis is extracted from www.sports-reference.com/cfb/schools/<school-name>/. You can find it in our GitHub repository [14]. It provides a csv file that we trimmed by excluding these three rows because the teams did not have SRS and SOS values:

- 1937 Virginia
- 2020 Connecticut
- 2020 Old Dominion

Rather than leveraging the full dataset, we decided to focus on the CFP era (2014-2024) as training inclusion criteria. Our training/validation split was 2014-2023 for training with 2024 held out. For our initial ex-ante 2025 predictions, we also use data through December 3, 2025 before the Big Ten and SEC conference championships.

During early exploratory work we posted on GitHub [14], we inadvertently allowed partial 2025 team-seasons into the CFP-era training set by filtering on $\text{Year} \geq 2014$ without an upper bound. This yielded 1,566 team-seasons and 11 champions. For all results reported here, we corrected this by restricting the training window to completed CFP-era seasons only (2014–2024). This yields 1,430 team-seasons and 11 champions. The dependent variable for “Champion” was defined as:

Polls_AP Post = 1
AND
Polls_CFP Final = not null

The AP Post was the final ranking after the season was completed. The CFP Final was the CFP ranking heading into the playoff tournament, and not null ensures only teams that played in the playoffs were included.

3.2 Statistical Tests

To conduct our statistical testing of hypotheses from section 2 we performed a logistic regression using the Maximum Likelihood Estimation (MLE) method as detailed in table 1 below:

Table 1. Logit Regression Results

Variable Name	Coefficient	P-Value Significance of Coefficient	Standard Error
Intercept	-54.189	0.003	18.465
Win%	49.549	.012	19.829
SRS	0.172	0.940	0.183
SOS	0.581	0.108	0.362

Win% has a huge coefficient of 49.5 compared to the tiny coefficients for SRS and SOS. The Pseudo R-squared (McFadden) was 0.797 and Log-Likelihood was -13.09 (LLR p-value: $3.836e-22$). Given Win% was significant at the 95% level, we rejected our global hypothesis that $H_0: \beta_1 = \beta_2 = \beta_3 = 0$ (all coefficients equal zero; predictors have no effect). Win% significantly affects championship probability.

Accordingly, we also reject our first single variable null hypothesis that Win% is not a statistically significant predictor. However, we are not rejecting our second and final single variable null hypotheses. Neither SRS nor SOS were significant. They are not helpful for inference to understand this statistical model, but our priority was predictive accuracy, thus we kept SOS and SRS in our machine learning model.

3.3 Machine Learning Model Architecture

For ML modeling we chose logistic regression with balanced class weighting from the scikit learn python library. We used StandardScaler for feature normalization. The feature coefficients were:

- 2.492 = Win%
- 2.221 = SRS
- 0.899 = SOS

Win% was the most important feature, followed by SRS. SRS is approximately 89% as influential as Win% ($2.221/2.492 = 0.891$). SOS was only moderately important. We achieved 80% historical accuracy on 2014-23 champions for validation. The champions we missed were 2016 (predicted Alabama, actual Clemson) and 2017 (predicted Wisconsin, actual Alabama).

We also considered other features such as the highest AP Poll ranking a team achieved during the regular season, preseason AP ranking, and CFP ranking. Some combinations had better predictive power, i.e., better than 80% historical accuracy, but they relied on the external human polls. We wanted a model that was driven only by the numbers.

3.4 ML Model Evaluation Metrics

To evaluate the binary model we looked at the Receiver Operating Characteristic curve (ROC) and got 0.998. As you can see with the orange line in Figure 1 below, nearly all of model falls in the “True Positive Rate”.

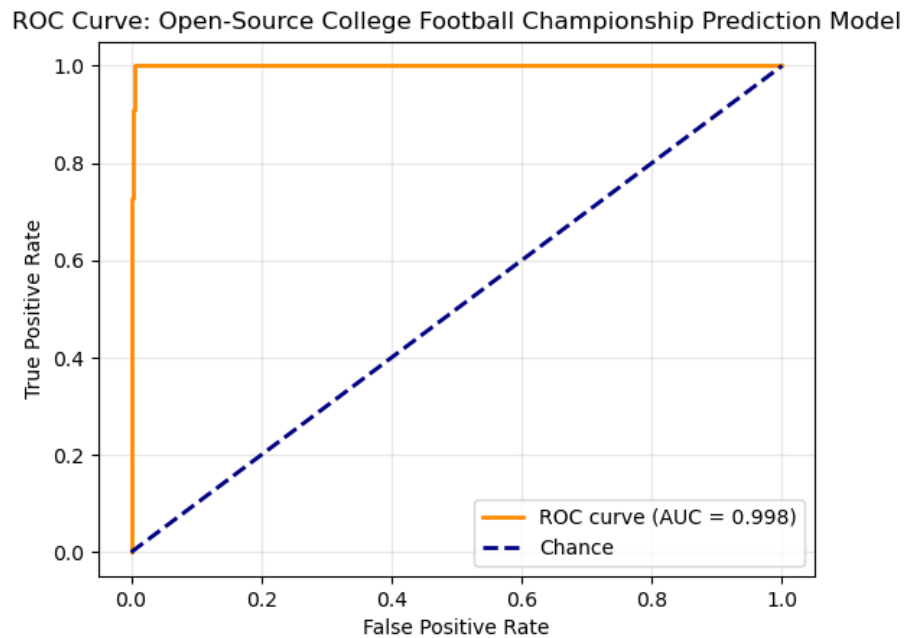


Fig. 1. ROC Curve for predictive model.

To detect multicollinearity we calculated Variance Inflation Factor (VIF). By feature it was:

- 1.960 = SRS
- 1.654 = SOS
- 1.271 = Win%

The scores between 1 and 2 indicate “Mild to moderate correlation (usually fine)” [16] and given they are under 10 we did not take any corrective steps.

Noting the statistical tests in subsection 3.2 involved failing to reject two null hypotheses, to ensure the variables we kept were all adding value, we also did Stratified 5-Fold Cross-Validation. We got 100% recall for champions and consistent performance across all five folds. All three features have non-zero, stable coefficients with bootstrap Confidence Intervals (CIs) that exclude zero:

- 2.06 (CI $\approx$ 1.73–2.29) = Win%
- 2.13 (CI $\approx$ 1.91–2.41) = SRS
- 1.03 (CI $\approx$ 0.71–1.35) = SOS

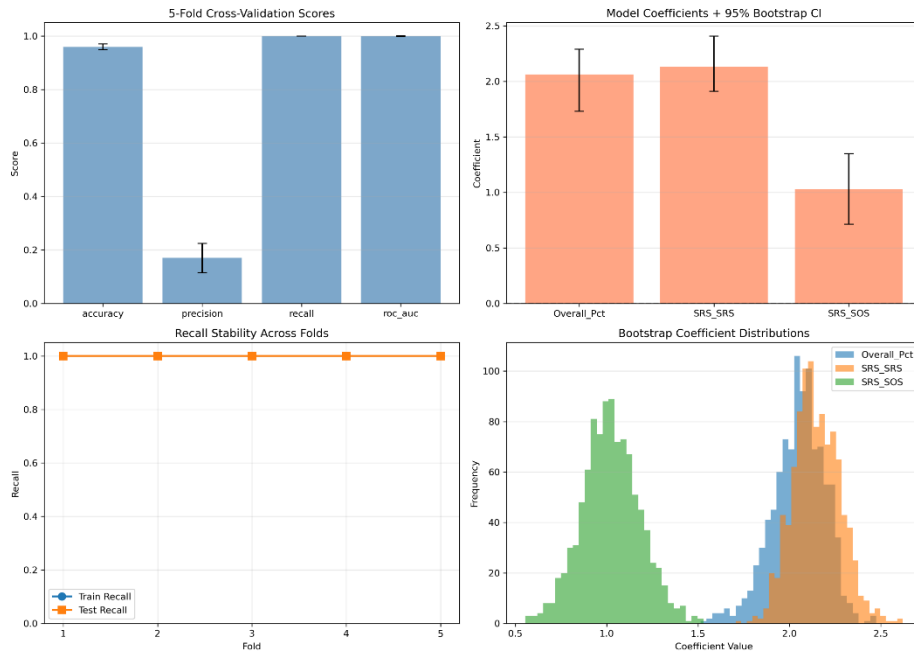


Fig. 2. Cross Fold Validation Data Visualizations

To further assess whether all features provide value, we compared the full three-feature model (Win%, SRS, SOS) to single-feature baselines trained on 2014–2024 data. All models achieved perfect recall for champions in this period, but the full model achieved higher precision (0.16 vs 0.09) and F1 (0.28 vs 0.16) than a Win%-only model, and substantially higher precision–recall AUC (0.77 vs 0.65) despite similar ROC AUC (0.998 vs 0.996). SRS alone also performed competitively (F1 = 0.26), indicating that feature contributes meaningfully to championship signaling.

3.5 Model Interpretability

The fitted logistic regression model produces a predicted probability of championship for each team-season. To help with interpretation we linearly rescaled to a 0–100 index

for each school. These probabilities are referred to as the IC^2 score, where higher values indicate greater estimated championship likelihood. IC^2 refers to the names of co-authors and contributors.

3.6 Comparison to Pre-CFP Era

Having just eleven positive championship targets across 1,430 total team-seasons is not ideal for our model. It affects learned coefficients and generalizability as well as limiting statistical confidence in the model's superiority over simpler heuristics. We cannot change the fact the CFP-era is roughly twelve years old and we want to preserve CFP-era training exclusivity. However, as a check on our approach we also tested if certain elements of predictability were "timeless". The CFB world has changed so much over the years, so we decided not to include data from the nineteenth century nor most of the twentieth. We looked at 1980 to 2003, before the CFP era began which added 34 championship targets across 3,905 team seasons. The biggest change was that in this time range SOS was a significant predictor while it was not in the CFP-era. All the other results were similar to the CFP-era ones which adds to the validity our model.

3.7 Champion Profile Criteria

To complement our predictive model, we also identified three criteria for a champion. These can be used quickly to determine a team's chances of winning a championship. Prior champions in the CFP era have the following characteristics:

- $Win\% \geq 0.875$
- $SRS \geq 20.1$
- $SOS \geq 5.2$

And these are the averages of the champions:

- Win%: 0.958
- SRS: 24.4
- SOS: 6.6

The number of criteria they have can be considered as its own score:

- 3: Championship profile
- 2: Near-complete profile, true contender
- 1: One-dimensional team
- 0: Not championship caliber

Only teams with a 2 or higher should be considered legitimate threats to win the playoffs.

4 Results

This study is observational and does not attempt to make causal claims; instead, it evaluates associations and predictive performance using historical data. We will begin by detailing our ex-ante 2025 predictions with data through December 3, 2025 and evaluate their accuracy. These were our top 10 teams on that date:

Table 2. Ex-ante top 10 teams with all features listed, score and profile..

Rank	IC ² Score	Championship Profile
1. Ohio State	96.628	2
2. Indiana University	94.188	2
3. Texas Tech	82.267	2
4. Texas A&M	81.150	1
5. Notre Dame	79.661	2
6. Brigham Young University	79.264	2
7. Oregon University	79.161	1
8. University of Georgia	69.215	1
9. University of Miami	62.332	0
10. University of Mississippi	57.997	1

We had the eventual champion, Indiana, ranked second. Following our initial ex-ante run no team had a score of 3. Indiana, Ohio State, Notre Dame, BYU and Texas Tech each had 2 of the 3 criteria. Miami had zero at that time, indicating they had not presented championship caliber play at that point. That changed later on in the tournament as they showcased they were able to play at the highest-level beating Texas A&M and Ohio State who were each ranked higher than them on December 3rd. They also beat Mississippi who was ranked just below them then at tenth.

"IC² Score" indicates the likelihood they will win the championship. The biggest difference between our results and the committee was the strength of Notre Dame, which only increased as the weeks proceeded after beginning the season 0-2 against Miami and Texas A&M they won ten games straight to end at 10-2. Both of their losses came to strong teams that participated in the College Football Playoff. The damage from their loss to Miami was dampened as the Hurricanes kept winning. However, no amount of dampening would make any Notre Dame fan feel better as by the end of the season those two losses kept them out of the CFP. Notre Dame was a popular pick to make the CFP and analytics seemed to love them but they just missed the cut in the end due to human voting. We had Notre Dame as #5 in our ranking and that was validated by having them as #5 in the final one.

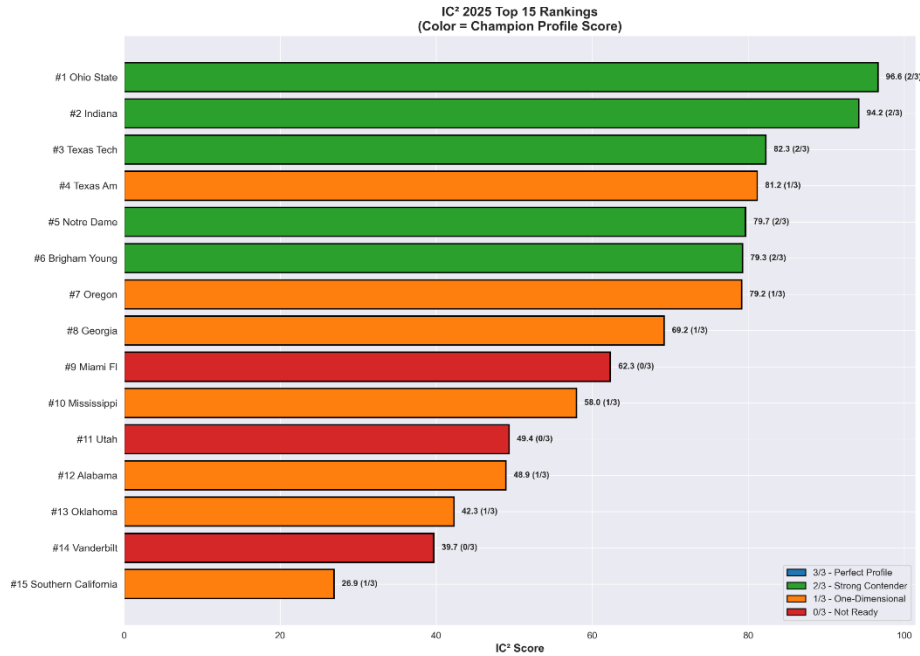


Fig. 3. Ex-ante top 15 bar chart with color coding for championship profile

At the same time Miami was #12 in the AP poll and Notre Dame was #9 in the week 15 rankings after the December 1st games [9]. Similarly, Miami was #12 in the CFP Committee Rankings on December 2nd [17] and Notre Dame was #10. Fans of the Fighting Irish had every reason to believe that they were going to make it to the playoffs but they were still left at the altar.

4.1 Predictions After Conference Championships

After Indiana beat Ohio State in the Big Ten Championship, we ran our model again on the updated results and had Indiana ranked first. Of course, almost everyone had that given Indiana was the only undefeated team between the Big Ten and SEC—the strongest conferences as measured by recent champions. The CFP committee followed suit, picking Indiana as the top seed for the playoffs.

So, heading into the playoff bracket Indiana had the highest score at 96.134 with a championship profile of 2. Miami had the 9th highest score at 61.338 with a championship profile of 0. Miami was the #10 seed in the playoff bracket [17] and the AP had them ranked #10 in their December 7 poll [9].

4.2 Final Model Rankings After the Season

Indiana won the championship, which was the outcome we predicted. Although this may not have been a farfetched prediction in this particular season, historically-

speaking no team in college football has lost as much as the Hoosiers. Their 715 all-time losses leads all FBS programs. Thus, having them at the top of any poll or a model predicting them to win a national championship would be unbelievable up until the clock hit 0:00 of the last game of the year with them leading. It was a truly unprecedented outcome and arguably the greatest coaching job of all time with Head Coach Curt Cignetti leading them from the CFB doldrums to holding its crown in the end. Having the runner up Miami, ranked slightly higher than the AP Poll and CFP bracket was an additional indication of the value of our model’s predictive approach.

With the results from the full season we did a final run. This analysis is descriptive and does not contribute to the cross-validated performance metrics, but it illustrates that the model’s learned notion of a “champion profile” is consistent with the eventual 2025 champion. At that time Indiana did have 3/3 championship criteria. Miami finished the year #4 with 2/3 championship criteria.

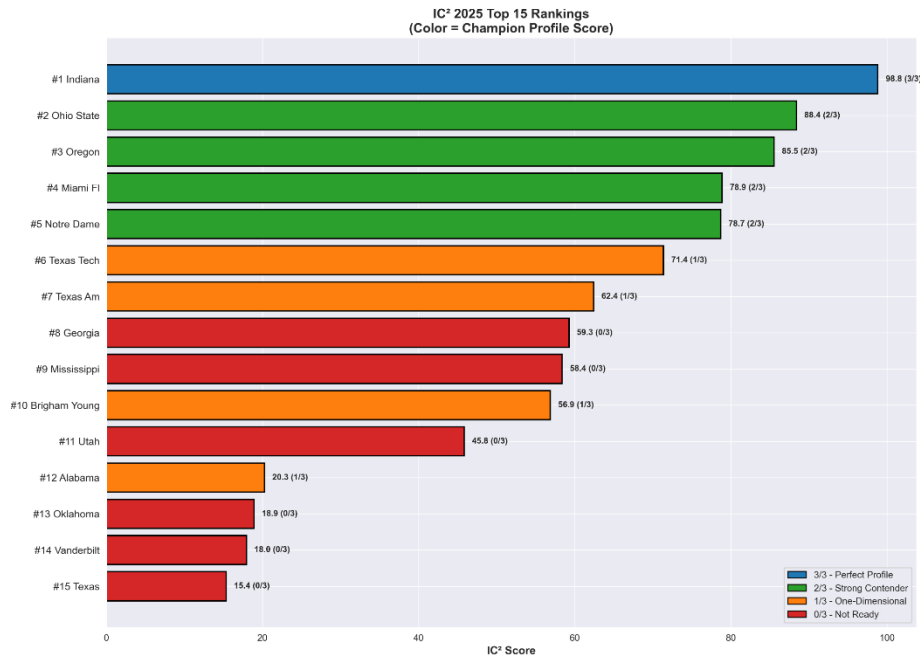


Fig. 4. Postseason top 15 bar chart with color coding for championship profile

5 Discussion

While we are excited about the initial results of our poll, we do feel it is important to acknowledge some limitations. The small number of features do help with interpretability, but they do not allow for capturing intangible factors like injuries and coaching changes. Additionally, the single-season test set (2024) has only N=1 positive.

We plan to improve the model each year going forward to address some of these limitations. An example of a model improvement would be to control for the Blue Chip ratio as a way to capture more nuanced team recruiting and talent information [18] [19]. Many in the college football world believe that the high-school recruiting pipeline, and now making good use of the transfer portal are the biggest keys to winning. As they say, sometimes it is about the Xs and Os of the game (tactical performance) but sometimes it matters more about who has the better Jimmy's and Joe's—hence the importance of capturing the impact of the Blue-Chip ratio.

The infamous exclusion of Notre Dame has led to new rules for the 2026-27 season where Notre Dame is guaranteed a spot in the playoff if they are in the top-12 of the selection committee's CFP rankings by season's end. Conference champions of the SEC, Big Ten, ACC, and Big XII (the "Power 4" conferences) are also guaranteed playoff spots going forward [15]. Heading into the 2026 season we will consider adapting our model after the guaranteed spots have been filled to identify the at-large teams selected with a championship profile who may have a strong showing in the playoffs, like Miami in 2025.

We are hopeful the open-source license of our code encourages others to improve the model themselves as well. You can find the full data file and python code on GitHub [14]. We plan to continue refining it going forward to develop a community driven quantitative ranking. There are also other open-source college football projects such as this Python wrapper for the CFBD API [20]. We would like to explore leveraging this tool to improve our open-source model.

In addition, we want to improve upon the existing scraper we made for the Sports Reference website. Our goal is a simple, practical analytics environment focused on shared access, transparency, and speed. JupyterHub would provide a shared, common workspace then Streamlit could enable us to easily turn our finding and insights into simple, interactive apps. In the backend we would use a MySQL database on a cloud server.

Beyond improving our tools, we want to consider applying our model to women's college football. Flag football has been added to the emerging sports program [21] so this feels like an auspicious time to begin preparing IC²-style, era-specific, interpretable models to support transparent rankings in this rapidly growing sport. We may be able to take advantage of the existing Women's 2025 IFAF Flag Football World Rankings [22].

6 Conclusion

It has seemingly become an annual autumn tradition to roast men's CFB polls. Whether it be whining that your team was unfairly ranked by The AP poll or how the CFP Selection Committee is biased towards big conferences. These frustrating results from human chosen rankings lead some to feel like ESPN reporter Bill Connelly has them "Extremely ready to go back to a BCS-like formula." [23]

Years after the BCS is gone, the desire to remove human bias to find the true "best" team in the country based purely on the numbers remains. Rather than teams of

large/popular fanbases what some consider the top two conferences (the SEC and Big Ten) that seemingly get favorable treatment. Of course, the formula had its own controversies which is why we now have the CFP.

We offer our model as a BCS for those who began watching college football in the 12-team CFP-era and for those who would like to see the computer rankings come back in some form. There are other quantitative rankings out there, but many, like the Colley Matrix [25] were designed last century before there was a playoff. Our CFP-era specific training avoids historical bias and we have simple, interpretable features complemented by a champion profile that provides transparency.

The introductory version of this model we presented in this paper has 80% historical accuracy and predicted Indiana as the winner before the playoffs began. Additionally, it had the runner-up, Miami, higher rated than the AP Poll or CFP. We hope readers of this paper will join us to make the open-source model even better going forward.

Acknowledgments. We would like to thank the conference organizers for the opportunity to submit this paper. We also want to thank the open-source sports analytics community that has been one of the inspirations for this work, especially those active on Reddit and Twitter.

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